

Anti-Inflammatory Diet Plan for Rheumatoid Arthritis

Practical NHS-backed advice on anti-inflammatory diet plan for rheumatoid arthritis uk.

By **Living With Arthritis** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: An anti-inflammatory diet for RA focuses on omega-3 rich oily fish, colourful vegetables, wholegrains, olive oil, and nuts — while reducing red meat, processed food, and refined sugar. This Mediterranean-style approach is supported by NICE guidance and Arthritis Research UK as a complement to medication.

No diet cures RA, but strong evidence shows anti-inflammatory eating reduces inflammatory markers, may improve joint pain and stiffness, and supports overall health alongside prescribed DMARDs.

The Mediterranean Diet Foundation

The Mediterranean diet is the most studied dietary pattern for RA. It's characterised by abundant vegetables, fruit, wholegrains, legumes, oily fish, olive oil, and moderate poultry and dairy — with red meat, processed food, and refined sugar eaten rarely.

Your Weekly Plate

- Daily: Colourful vegetables (5+ portions), wholegrains, olive oil as main cooking fat, 2L water
- 3–4 times weekly: Oily fish (salmon, sardines, mackerel), legumes, nuts (especially walnuts)

- Minimise: Red and processed meat, white bread and pastry, sugary drinks, ultra-processed foods
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Key Nutrients for RA



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Omega-3 fatty acids from oily fish have the strongest evidence — they reduce leukotriene production driving RA inflammation. Aim for at least two portions of oily fish per week. Vitamin D deficiency is very common in RA — ask your GP to test your levels and consider supplementation.

Q&A;

Question: Can diet replace my RA medication? **Short answer:** No. Diet is a valuable complement to medication but cannot replace DMARDs or biologics. Never stop prescribed medication without discussing it with your rheumatologist.

Question: Are there foods that definitively worsen RA? **Short answer:** Studies link high red meat consumption, processed food, and refined sugar with increased inflammatory markers in RA. Alcohol can also interact with methotrexate and should be limited.

Question: Should I take omega-3 supplements if I don't eat fish? **Short answer:** Algae-based omega-3 supplements are a good alternative for vegetarians and vegans. Discuss dose with your GP or rheumatologist.